E-cigarette Indirect Promotion Strategies Annotation Codebook: Malaysia's TikTok Videos

This codebook serves as a standardized instrument for the systematic coding and classification of indirect e-cigarette promotion strategies in Malaysian TikTok videos.

Indirect promotion is defined as content where e-cigarette branding, products, or vaping-related behaviours are present in the textual caption or video, yet direct promotional elements such as direct advertisements, sales catalogues, "hard-sell" product reviews, or giveaways are absent. Non promotional content such as legitimate public health education, medical warnings and objective news reporting regarding e-cigarette regulations or incidents were excluded from this coding scheme.

Classification is based strictly on manifest visual and audio content presented within the video. No inference beyond what is directly presented in the video should be made. Video captions are excluded from the primary classification logic, as they are frequently too brief to provide meaningful context for identifying subtle indirect marketing.

The indirect promotion strategies categories within this codebook were developed through an iterative deductive-inductive process. This involved the comprehensive, full-length review and manual coding of a pilot dataset (n=130) of Malaysian TikTok videos featuring indirect e-cigarette promotion, followed by refinement through consensus discussion.

Coding Structure

Each promotional strategy was coded as:

0 = Absent

1 = Present

A video may be assigned multiple strategies where applicable. When uncertain, coders should adopt a conservative approach and code as absent.

Indirect promotion strategies

1. Product Placement (PP)

Definition:

Product placement is defined as the visual display of e-cigarette-related products, branding, or behaviours within a video, without explicit explanation or direct promotional messaging.

Operational Criteria

Code PP = yes if any of the following criteria are identified:

1. Device: The presence of e-cigarette device(s) or their packaging, which may include pods, mods, vape pens, or "stealth" devices that mimic everyday objects such as USB flash drives, pens, highlighters, toys, cigars, or pipes, particularly when they bear identifiable brand markings.
2. E-liquid: Visibility of e-liquid bottles or their packaging, often characterized by tapered tips and vibrant, flavour-oriented packaging.
3. Merchandise: The presence of e-cigarette branded merchandise such as lanyards, T-shirts, caps, helmets, or other items displaying e-cigarette brand names or logos.
4. Brand: The clear display of an e-cigarette brand name or logo on any surface within the video frame.
5. Vaping behaviour: Visual depiction of vaping actions or performance of vaping tricks.

Examples of inclusion:

Criteria	Example of inclusion	Justification of inclusion
E-cigarette device(s)	In a food review video, an e-cigarette brand name is clearly displayed in the background alongside multiple e-cigarette devices. 	E-cigarette brand name and devices are clearly visible.
E-cigarette related merchandise	An influencer wears an e-cigarette-branded lanyard in a comedy skit about collecting parcels. 	The lanyard is identifiable as e-cigarette-branded merchandise.
Vaping behaviour	A video shows a creator blowing vapor clouds. 	Presence of vaping behaviour.

Criteria	Example of inclusion	Justification of inclusion
Brand	Presence of e-cigarette brand name at the top of video frame in a 360º video booth clip. 	Clear display of e-cigarette brand name.

Example of exclusion:

Criteria	Example of exclusion	Justification for exclusion
E-cigarette device and merchandise	An influencer talking on the phone wears an orange lanyard with illegible small text, and the attached item is not visible. 	No identifiable e-cigarette branding or device.

2. Youth Appeal (YA)

Definition**:**

Youth appeal refers to the presence of youth-oriented features within videos containing e-cigarette-related content, based on an adapted Content Appealing to Youth (CAY) framework.

Operational Criteria

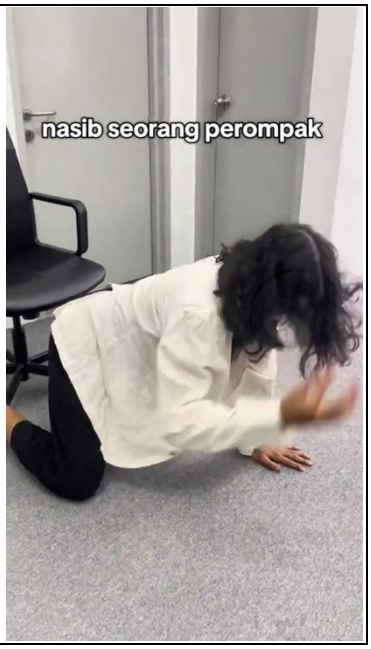
Code YA = yes if any of the following criteria are identified:

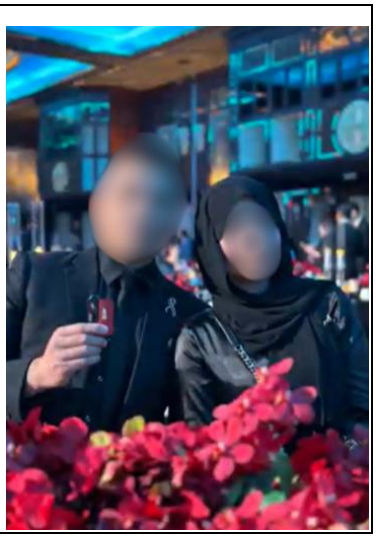
1. Character appeal is present when a character fulfils ANY of the following criteria:
    a. Youth: Any human actor with a visible face who appears to be under approximately 25 years old, based on facial features, clothing, or styling.
    b. Animated character: Any non-human or stylized human figure presented as a cartoon, drawing/sketch, computer-generated image (CGI), avatar, or animated sticker.
    c. fictional character: Any non-real, imagined, or symbolic character including superheroes, mythical figures, or individuals portrayed through costumes, cosplay, or mascot representations.
2. A youth-oriented theme is present with ANY of the following elements are identified:
    a. Humour: Presence of any action, dialogue, or storyline clearly intended to provoke laughter or amusement such as jokes, pranks, parodies, or exaggerated reactions.
    b. Magic or fantasy: presence of any supernatural or fantasy element such as magical transformation, fantasy setting, or impossible events.
3. Product appeal is present when the e-cigarette device, e-liquid, packaging, or its image is presented in an attention-drawing manner as in ANY of the following:
    a. bright or vibrant colour: high intensity and saturation colour such as neon/fluorescent colours, primary hues such as yellow, orange, red, jewel tones of royal blue or emerald green
    b. multiple colours or colourful design: more than one colour used
    c. high colour contrast: The product contains areas of distinctly contrasting brightness or colour intensity.
    d. shiny or glossy appearance: The device primarily features shiny or reflective surfaces.
    e. smooth surface
    f. visible vapour or smoke emitted from using the device
4. Rewarding appeal is present when the video implies desirable outcomes associated with e-cigarette use or possession, including:

a. Positive mood or sensory appeal: The video suggests that e-cigarette use is associated with relaxation, happiness, enjoyment, fun, pleasurable sensory experience.
b. camaraderie: The video shows e-cigarette uses or display together with friendship, closeness, group bonding, party scenes, shared learning or instruction that creates a sense of belonging.
c. achievement/success: The video suggests that e-cigarette use or display is associated with success, achievement, confidence in reaching goals, social, financial, athletic, or personal advantage
d. sexual connotation: The video contains sexualized pose or behaviour, nudity, lewd or suggestive imagery, implication of sexual encounter in relation to e-cigarette
e. Individuality: The video suggests that e-cigarette use or display represents being unique, independence, self-expression or taking control of one's life
f. social status or positioning: The video suggests that e-cigarette use or display is associated with popularity, standing out, admiration from others or higher social status
g. Romantic connotation: The video clearly implies romance, love, affection, flirting or marriage in relation to e-cigarette.
h. Adventure or spontaneity: The video associates e-cigarette uses or display with adventure, thrill, excitement, impulsive or spontaneous activity

Examples of inclusion:

Criteria	**Example of inclusion**	**Justification for inclusion**
Character appeal (youth)	A comedy skit about searching for food features a child actor. 	One of the actors is a youth below 25 years old

Criteria	Example of inclusion	Justification for inclusion
Character appeal (animation)	An influencer lip-syncs to a Dragon Ball theme song with animated characters in frame. 	Dragon Ball is a youth appealing animation.
Youth-oriented theme	The actor made a *Roti Canai* that mimic the shape of deceased person trapped in their white shroud (*kain kafan*) and responded with a big laugh. 	Presence of humour and supernatural theme
Youth-oriented theme	Parody about a doctor saving a robber's life and the robber end up with a death sentence for his crime. 	Presence of humour indicated by exaggerated reactions.

Criteria	Example of inclusion	Justification for inclusion
Product appeal	A comedy skit in an office where a bright yellow e-cigarette device with a lanyard is worn, while another shiny blue device is visible on a table. 	The e-cigarette device is appealing to youth with vibrant colour, shiny and smooth surface.
Product appeal	A couple attending a night gala and posing with e-cigarette device held on his hand. 	Although the e-cigarette device held on the hand did not have vibrant colour, but the product appeal lies on the smooth surface and use of multiple colours.

Example of exclusion:

Criteria	Example of exclusion	Justification for exclusion
Character appeal	An influencer wearing a face mask apologizes for an unauthorized video post. 	Age cannot be determined due to facial obstruction.

3. Viral Marketing (VM)

Definition

Viral marketing refers to content designed to increase reach, engagement, or shareability using platform-specific features.

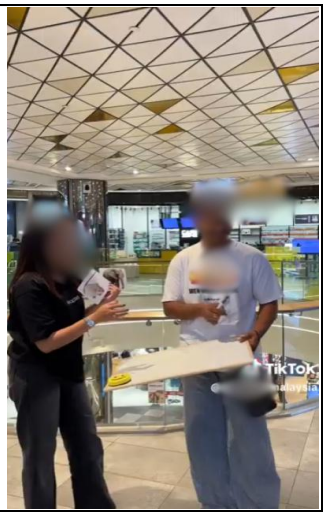
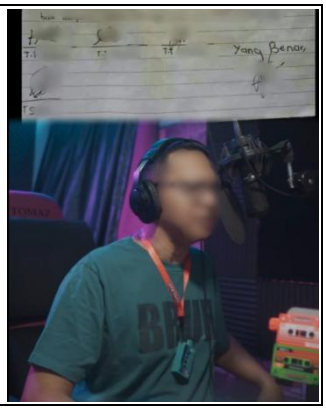
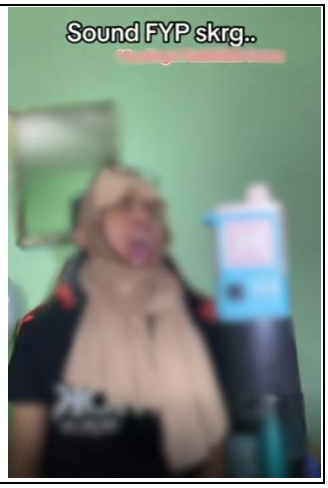
Operational Criteria

Code VM = yes if any of the following criteria are identified:

1. Newsjacking: the video employs the Video Reply to Comments format (where a creator creates a new video to respond to a specific comment displayed in a text overlay) or commenting on news events or trending topics to ride the wave of public interest.
2. Gamification: Using interactive elements, Gamified AR Filters (Augmented Reality effects that respond to head, face, eye, or hand movements) or physical games, quizzes, street interview or challenges that encourage users to participate in or share the content themselves.
3. Collaborations with other creators: Utilizing TikTok's built-in collaborative tools like Stitches (clipping a part of another video) or Duets (playing a video side-by-side with another) or incorporation of other creators' content.
4. Engagement cues: Using explicit verbal or textual overlays such as mentions of the FYP (For You Page), "challenge", "trend", or explicit prompts encouraging likes, shares, comments, or follows.
5. Exclusion: Use of audio editing effect, or other common TikTok editing effect such as animations, transitions, or other stylized effects that have no interactive features as in AR filters; pranks, jokes and parody lack voluntary participation and mutual enjoyment, thus not considered as gamification as well.

Examples of inclusion:

Criteria	Example of inclusion		Justification for inclusion
Newsjacking	Comment on a renowned football player joining new football club and his performance.		Commenting on news events about football player with interspersed third-party footage of football event is a form of newsjacking.
Newsjacking	An influencer uses a Video Reply to Comments to give their "hot take" on an e-cigarette review.		Presence to Video Reply to Comments chat bubble as pointed out by influencer.
Gamification (digital)	A creator uses an AR Filter game to sing the song that starts with the word as indicated.		AR filter game is a form of digital game.

Criteria	Example of inclusion		Justification for inclusion
Gamification (physical)	A street interview in a shopping mall included a game of drawing animal as indicated.		The drawing game is a form of physical game
Collaborations with other creators	A voice over artist reading a love letter by school children that appear on top of the video frame.		This is in duet format as two contents from different creator occur concurrently in a video frame.
Engagement cues	Influencer lip-sync singing to the trending song as indicated by “Sound FYP”.		The mention of “FYP” serves as an explicit engagement cue.

Criteria	Example of inclusion	Justification for inclusion
Engagement cues	An influencer giveaway cash when the random passerby followed his TikTok account and invited viewer to click follow at the end of the video. 	Verbal invitation along with text overlay of "Follow" to invite engagement.

Examples of exclusion:

Criteria	Example of exclusion	Justification for exclusion
Gamification (digital)	Video on putting on stickers on motorcycle with snowflake transitions in between clips. 	Transition effect or other stylized effect is not considered as digital game as it does not provide interactive gaming element such as in AR filter that respond to head, face, eye, or hand movements
Gamification (physical)	A comedy skit about the husband pranked the wife on job application. 	Pranks are not considered forms of gamification because they do not involve structured participation or interactive gameplay.

4. Event Sponsorship (ES)

Definition

Event sponsorship refers to the depiction or promotion of events sponsored by e-cigarette brands, without explicit product promotion.

Operational Criteria

Code ES = yes if any of the following criteria are identified:

1. Infrastructure: Visible evidence of event sponsorship via e-cigarette branded booths/stalls, stages, or backdrop banners in a setting intended for large public gatherings, excluding isolated studio recording setting.
2. Sports event: E-cigarette brand logos or names displayed on the official jerseys or uniforms of sports players in a setting that enable large crowd gatherings.
3. Event promotion: Use of digital posters, text overlays, or verbal announcements to invite viewers to an upcoming event where e-cigarette brand is listed as one of the sponsors.

Examples of inclusion:

Criteria	**Example of inclusion**	**Justification for inclusion**
Infrastructure	An interview of the best winner of snooker competition at a stage with e-cigarette branded backdrop. 	The branded backdrop is a physical event infrastructure for a snooker competition.
Promotion	A boxer thanking e-cigarette brand for the sponsorship and invite viewer to the upcoming competition.	Promotion of boxing competition sponsored by e-cigarette brand.

Criteria	Example of inclusion	Justification for inclusion
		

Example of exclusion:

Criteria	Example of exclusion	Justification for exclusion
Infrastructure	Night gala event at a ball room. 	No evidence from physical infrastructure that the event is sponsored by e-cigarette industry.
Promotion	A man played guitar and invited viewer to attend the upcoming motorcycle gathering. 	No evidence in the video that suggests the motorcycle gathering is sponsored by e-cigarette industry.

5. Localization (Loc)

Definition

Localization refers to the intentional incorporation of cultural, religious, or national elements to embed e-cigarette-related content within local cultural context.

Operational Criteria

Code Loc = yes if any of the following criteria are identified:

1. Traditional culture: Presence of traditional attire specifically during traditional festival (*Hari Raya*, Chinese New Year, Deepavali or Christmas) or ceremony (wedding or funeral) or the context traditional festivities or ceremony with or without the use of traditional attire.
2. Religious integration: Content that references religious teachings, practices, or religious settings.
3. Nationalism: Central themes focusing on national solidarity, independence celebration, or explicit emphasis on national language, local dialects, ethnic identity, or state identity.
4. Exclusion: Daily use of Malay language, local slang, common religious saying (Alhamdulillah, Insya-Allah), standard *Baju Kurung/Baju Melayu/Songkok* worn as daily attire, incidental flags, landmarks on shirts, or simple mentions of "Malaysia" or state names unless these elements constitute the primary focus of the video narrative.

Examples of inclusion:

Criteria	**Example of inclusion**	**Justification for inclusion**
Traditional culture	A content creator promoting traditional "*Baju Melayu*" for *Hari Raya* festival. 	Presence of local traditional festival with traditional attire element.

Criteria	Example of inclusion	Justification for inclusion
Traditional culture	A group of friends in *Baju Kurung* with the bride in traditional wedding attire. 	The presence of traditional attire in traditional ceremony.
Religion	Wishing happy fasting (*puasa*) to all e-cigarette users. 	Highlighted the religious practice of fasting.
Nationalism	An interview about the motivation of creating Malay songs abroad. 	Highlighted the nationalism through motivation of creating a song using national language.